The Atlantic Charter

President Roosevelt & Prime Minister Churchill · USS Augusta, off Newfoundland · August 14, 1941

Source: The Atlantic Charter (Aug. 14, 1941), text via the Avalon Project, Yale Law School. Public domain.

Four months before Pearl Harbor, FDR and Churchill met secretly aboard warships off Newfoundland and issued this joint statement of Allied war aims — even though the U.S. was not yet at war. The Charter committed the two leaders to a postwar world built on self-determination, free trade, freedom of the seas, and a 'permanent system of general security' (the seed of the United Nations). It also publicly aligned the U.S. with Britain against the Axis powers.

Connect: The Atlantic Charter's principles (self-determination, free trade) echo Wilson's Fourteen Points (Class 39). Did FDR learn from Wilson's failures?

Key Passages

Self-determination

> First, their countries seek no aggrandizement, territorial or other; Second, they desire to see no territorial changes that do not accord with the freely expressed wishes of the peoples concerned; Third, they respect the right of all peoples to choose the form of government under which they will live; and they wish to see sovereign rights and self government restored to those who have been forcibly deprived of them;

Freedom from fear and want

> Sixth, after the final destruction of the Nazi tyranny, they hope to see established a peace which will afford to all nations the means of dwelling in safety within their own boundaries, and which will afford assurance that all the men in all lands may live out their lives in freedom from fear and want; Seventh, such a peace should enable all men to traverse the high seas and oceans without hindrance;

Disarmament

> Eighth, they believe that all of the nations of the world, for realistic as well as spiritual reasons must come to the abandonment of the use of force. … they believe, pending the establishment of a wider and permanent system of general security, that the disarmament of such nations is essential.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	World War II in Europe: Germany had conquered much of Europe and invaded the Soviet Union; the U.S. was not yet at war but aided Britain through Lend-Lease.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The American and British publics, the Axis powers, occupied nations, and the wider world.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Roosevelt and Churchill, Allied leaders who wanted a democratic postwar order; British imperial interests and colonized peoples' wishes are in tension.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. Contextualization (DBQ/LEQ, 1 pt): Place the Atlantic Charter in the broader path from U.S. neutrality (1939) to war (Dec. 1941).
2. Compare the Atlantic Charter with Wilson’s Fourteen Points. What’s the same? What’s different?
3. Which principle of the Charter was most violated in the postwar settlement?